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The Sabbath & the Crystal Palace.

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*** START OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE SABBATH
AND THE CRYSTAL PALACE ***

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THE SABBATH AND THE CRYSTAL PALACE.

THE question of Sabbath observance is again brought before the public, and subjected to a new discussion. Points which we had considered as settled, and settled beyond the reach of doubt, are disputed. A change of circumstances is stated as requiring and involving a change of views; and the character which society is assuming in the present day, is said to justify a revision and reconsideration of the principles by which it has been previously regulated. A fresh attack in consequence is made on an ordinance which, having been accustomed to regard as the security of our national religion, the source of those streams of life which sanctify and refresh the souls of our people, we had hoped was secured from encroachment and curtailment by the law of the land, as well as by the authority of the word of God. The attack in this case, as might have been expected, comes from a different quarter, and is carried on in a different manner. It is not with open and avowed enemies that we have to contest the point, but with professed friends. Much for which we have contended on former occasions is conceded now. In many respects, the tone, the language, the object of those opposed to us are modified. The divine institution of a day of rest is admitted; the beneficent character of the appointment, its salutary influences, are acknowledged; its peculiar adaptation to the condition of man is recognised: and the only subject of dispute would seem to be, the form in which those influences should be exercised, and the general application of the blessing intended should be accomplished.

The good of man, the improvement of the labouring classes, the softening of their character, the refinement of their tastes, the development of intellect, and the correction of what is low and sensual in their enjoyments, are named as the objects of pursuit: and no one can hesitate as to the importance of these points, nor as to the value which all things lovely and of good report possess in christian estimation. With a view to the

promotion of these objects, the advantages of a day of rest; its beneficent influence on the mind as well as the body; its increasing importance in a state of society like the present; its absolute necessity when man is exposed to the exhausting circumstances of manufacturing or commercial life, are admitted,—and not only admitted, but urged with as much zeal as was ever shown by those who contended for the strictest observance of the Sabbath in the days of religious controversy. Surprise and regret are therefore mixed together, when we find that those who see the importance of the institution in one sense so clearly, and can advocate its claims with so much power, should disappoint the expectations that had been indulged of their co-operation, and should finally become the assailants instead of the supporters of the principle we feel bound to maintain. They see so much in the institution of the Sabbath that is adapted to the weaknesses and wants of our nature, that they cannot help acknowledging its necessity. Under that conviction, forced upon them by the outcry of the whole creation, groaning and travailing together in pain, by the testimony of exhausted bodies and paralyzed intellect, they admit, they assert, as a fact that can no longer be denied, that the Sabbath was made for man, and accept it as a merciful provision made by God for the relief and consolation of his creatures; but as to the specific purpose which it is to serve in respect of man, as to the way in which the balm is to be used and applied, they have their own views, and those views they are determined to carry out in opposition to all that has been established and believed on the subject. It is clear, then, that we have not gained much by the concessions made by those who have been induced, under these representations, and with these views of the ordinance, to admit the divine authority of the Sabbath. They have attempted to disarm our opposition by professing to receive the same truth, while they were introducing views which superseded its application; and the controversy must now be transferred from the religious authority of the Sabbath, as a day of rest, to the form and manner of its observance by those who, on these grounds, acknowledge its obligation.

The point at issue with our present opponents consists chiefly as to the manner in which the Sabbath is to be applied. Its value they admit; its beneficent effects are acknowledged to be such that its divine authority can hardly be disputed: but while they argue with us in considering that the Sabbath was made for man, they differ widely from us as to the way and

manner in which it is to be used, and as to the benefits to be expected or derived from its observance. We are compelled, from the language made use of, to say, that they regard the Sabbath as having been made for man, much as we believe that it was made for the animals that are placed under man's government, and are thus made partakers of his life of labour. In consequence, the sort of rest that they anticipate in the Sabbath for man, differs only from that which is ordained for them, as the constitution of man differs from that of the brute creation, and requires a different species of rest, in reference to a different form of toil. The rest of the animal is provided for when the exaction of labour ceases, and natural wants are supplied. The rest for man, according to their view, is equally provided for, when liberty is given to body and mind, and the refreshment that is required by each, in order to supply the exhaustion that has taken place, is put within its reach. The wearied limbs require sleep, the wearied senses quiet; and the first object is to ensure the repose which the physical frame requires after its six days' labour. In the case of man, however, when repose and quiet have produced this effect on the body, and the mind, regaining its activity, looks round for relaxation, there then ensues another necessity, for there is another want to be provided for; and something more must be done for the refreshment of the human system than had been found necessary before. An effort, therefore, is to be made to supply to all what seems the universal want of those who labour; and the wearied mind must have its food and rest, just as the wearied body has had before, in order to perfect the object for which the Sabbath is appointed.

It is proposed, therefore, to apply the afternoon of the Sabbath to such recreations as may refine the taste while they amuse the man, and to effect an improvement in the general character of our population, by supplying them with the means of intellectual and innocent amusement during the interval of leisure. Among the means of promoting this end, and with this as one of its avowed objects, public attention is being drawn to the Crystal Palace erecting at Sydenham, which is, we hear, to be opened every Sunday afternoon, as offering in a small compass, a collection of those objects which are most likely to attract the notice and elevate the tastes of the people. The energy and talent which are engaged in carrying out the plan of this magnificent undertaking, leave no room for doubt as to their success. It is easy to imagine that such an assemblage of the wonders of nature and art

will never have been presented to the public in modern days, or presented under such favourable circumstances. The immense size of the building contemplated, we are told, will admit of the introduction of all the wonders of tropical vegetation, combined with copies of the finest works of art. The whole world is to be laid under contribution to complete the interest of the scene, and things which we have only heard and read of, are to be offered to the inspection of the multitude. Models of machinery, specimens of workmanship, the trophies of the skill of our own people, and of foreign nations, are to be presented for examination and study, that the exhibition may be made as profitable and instructive, as it must be interesting and attractive.

It is not easy to state too highly the amount of innocent and elevating amusement that may be derived from such a combination of objects. The knowledge slowly gained by books will be here anticipated by what is seen. A few hours spent in the Palace, with an intelligent guide, may teach more than had been learnt in months of study; and what is of more consequence, those who never would have learnt anything from books, may here gain much from seeing; and a spirit of inquiry may be kindled in minds which had resisted every other mode of teaching. We are assured, also, that the exhibition is to be kept as free from the ordinary cause of evil, as it is unexceptionable in its original design. No liquor of an intoxicating kind is to be sold there. Order and propriety of behaviour will be maintained by the officials; and the freedom of access is to be general, and every indulgence afforded to intelligent curiosity; no deviation will be permitted from the rules laid down at first.

It is not without a pang that we proceed to disperse this brilliant vision, and to show the danger that lies concealed under this specious and captivating project. But let it be at once said, that the objections about to be urged against this fascinating scheme, are simply and exclusively directed against its Sunday exhibition. On other days we may regard it as an instance of the luxurious character of the age, as a wonderful example of the wealth possessed, and of the homage paid to the public; and if some fears mix themselves with the admiration that must be felt for the grandeur of the idea, and the boldness of the speculation, we may still be thankful for the evidence thus given of an improving taste in the character of our recreations, and for the care that is taken by individuals to cultivate and

direct the rising intellect of the people. Our chief, our only real objection to the scheme, consists in its being opened to the public on Sunday afternoon; and in this we think the error of its undertakers, the hollowness and unsoundness of the arguments by which they are recommending it, must be manifest to all who will deal fairly with the question, and give themselves the trouble of considering it. The Sabbath was made for man, they say; and they think, that in providing recreation and innocent amusement, as well as rest from labour for man, they have answered the purpose of the institution, by the provision thus made for mind as well as body.

The Sabbath was made for man, we say also; but the view we take of man, lets in a light on wants and necessities in his nature, of which we have, hitherto, been allowed to hear nothing. The Sabbath was made for man, we say; and we adore the wisdom as well as the benevolence exhibited in the ordinance; but it was not made for man merely as an intellectual creature, an animal gifted with various talents, and subject to various wants, but, at the same time, possessed of no other capacities than those of mind and sense, and liable to no other accidents than those which affect mind or body. According to our view, and we feel that our view must be that of the whole christian world, it was made for man as a being born for eternity,—as created in his Maker's likeness,—as fallen from his high original, but capable of restoration,—and as born under a system which unfolds the scheme devised by Infinite Wisdom, for the accomplishment of this great and glorious purpose. It was made for man, we say, as a spiritual and eternal existence, for a time clothed with flesh, subjected to the infirmities of the body, and the perverse influences of the mind, placed in the world with the view of developing in a state of trial, the graces and glories that belong to a higher nature, but destined to be a partaker of the inheritance of everlasting bliss. It was made for him, for his refreshment and repose under the burdens of his lot,—for the enlargement and perfection of his intellectual powers, by directing them to things above the world; and thus for the purpose of cherishing and strengthening that spiritual growth, which is the only real end of his being on earth, as it is the fulfilment of the will of God concerning him.

For this purpose we say the Sabbath was ordained. In this sense we can say that it was made for man, for we here perceive its merciful adaptation to the complicated wants of his mixed and mysterious nature. In the Sabbath,

therefore, thus understood, and thus applied, we see the depth of the riches both of the wisdom and the goodness of God, and we adore the mercy which provided alleviations for a life doomed to labour, and cheered the burdened traveller on his way, by the pledge of a rest eternal in the heavens. With this view of the Sabbath before us,—with this picture of its purpose and its end,—while we thus gaze on the glorious destiny unfolded to man in the institutions of the Sabbath, and see the steps by which he is prepared to inherit it in its sanctifying influences,—we must feel that all the temporal advantages offered to him here—the refinement of tastes, the enlargement of knowledge, are but a mockery of his woe, if they are proposed as the blessings connected with the ordinance; and we wonder at the audacity that can present such a petty allurements to the inheritor of the kingdom, as worthy of his acceptance.

But the real character of the Sabbath may be inferred, with greater confidence, from considering the character of the Being by whom it was ordained; for if the Sabbath was made for man, and made for man by Him who created man, it surely is reasonable that we should collect the character of the institution from the known will of the Institutor, and learn the way in which it should be observed from what we know of His general purpose. If the Sabbath, then, was made for man, let us remember, that it was made for man by Him who not only formed man from the dust, and breathed into him the breath of life, so that man became a living soul, but who likewise opened heaven to his view, raised him above the earth by the word of promise, and who, finally, sent his own blessed Son into the world to accomplish his restoration, Luke xix. 10.

Scripture, therefore, directs us to estimate the real value of attainments by the effect they produce upon the soul, rather than by what is exhibited,—to dread the knowledge which puffs up,—to shun that friendship of the world which separates us from God,—to check and to mortify the love of earthly things,—that the heart may be given, in all its fulness, to Him who claims it as his own, and the mind may be fixed on things above, rather than on those below. In a word, we must be conscious, that the gospel was given to make us good, rather than to make us great,—to fit us for heaven, rather than for earth; and though the goodness of God has so wonderfully combined the effects which it produces, that they are frequently united, the godliness has the promise of the life that now is, as well as of that which is to come; we

cannot have a moment's doubt as to that which is the higher and the nobler object, or as to that which must be the will of God concerning ourselves.

If these things, then, be so,—if the will of God is clearly, unequivocally declared, with regard to these objects of our pursuit at present, can there be a question as to those which are to be preferred? What is the knowledge of the world, what is taste, what is civilization itself, in comparison with the blessings included in his favour? and if it were possible to obtain them by the sacrifice of religious principle, what would they be to the possessor, but the colours which deck the serpent, the sweetness which conceals the poison it conveys.

We must feel, then, that when men talk of the beneficent effects to be produced by a sabbath, while that sabbath refers only to the physical or intellectual part of man, they greatly and grossly err; and that if, unhappily, this scheme should be realized, the soul would be sacrificed to the body, eternity to time, and the real purpose of man's being to the indulgence of vain and frivolous imaginations. But while the main question is met in this way, and the promoters of the scheme are reminded of its insufficiency for the object which they profess to have at heart—the improvement of the labouring classes—it is hoped that the legislature will bear in mind the price at which these refreshments for those who are inclined to partake of them must be purchased. On the Sabbath day at present, the parks, the outlets of the metropolis, are filled with crowds who prefer the amusement they can find there, to the religious improvement of the day which God has consecrated. We must regret the breach of the commandment, the offence offered to God, and the injury done to the sabbath-breakers themselves; but we feel that, in doing this, they claim no right to dictate to the practice of others, nor have they the power of compelling others to act against their own conscientious convictions. They may wish for refreshments, but they cannot compel the shops to be opened for their supply; and those windows which were unclosed through the six preceding days, are sealed to them on this, and offer a shelter against the tyranny of a God-despising world. Up to this time the laws of the country have endeavoured to prevent the licence of one man from trespassing on the liberty of another; and if they have not always succeeded in doing so, they have left no room for doubt as to their intentions. Up to this time, therefore, those who call themselves the servants of the public, have been allowed to feel that there was One greater

than the public, who cares for the weak and the dependent, and who restrains within certain limits the measure of labour that is exacted from them. The theatres, the places of public amusement, have, on this account, been closed; the post-office has suspended its issues; the transactions of business have been stopped; legal acts have been declared null and void. It has been declared that the command was general, for that its intention was, "that thy servant may rest as well as thou;" and it has been the privilege of the Englishman to feel that on this day the slave of the world was free from his master.

A new era, however, will be commenced with the chartered existence of the Crystal Palace, should such an outrage be permitted. Hundreds of officials will be called into stated attendance, and will be compelled to wait on the fancies of an ungodly multitude. Thousands of the unhappy and depressed class who are now engaged in furnishing the means of public conveyance, will be put into requisition, and tens and hundreds of thousands of the young and thoughtless will be swept away by the stream, and be made victims to a plan for improving the taste and enlarging the intellect of the irreligious section of our metropolitan operatives. It must be added, that the evil will not be confined to this single case. The precedent established here will be immediately followed in other places, and in all parts of the kingdom. The British Museum, the galleries, the exhibitions, will be thrown open in London. The curators in all these will be crushed with the burden of unsuspended labour, and the population, maddened by excitement, when excitement is substituted for the rest they need, will be the ready instruments for executing the judgments which will infallibly follow on such an act of national delinquency. Nor let it be forgotten, that this scheme, which, falling in with the prevailing humours of the day, is hailed by the immoral, or, at least, by the irreligious part of our people, as an accession to their resources of amusement, will be to many a bitter aggravation of a life of toil, by wresting from them that Sabbath which has, hitherto, been their only season of repose. But what is of more consequence, and which claims the serious consideration of the legislature, it will be an outrage such as has not yet been offered to the conscience and religious feelings of many who specially deserve the protection, if not the favour, of the legislature. For it must not be assumed because a cry is got up on behalf of the scheme, that all classes concur in welcoming the change

that is proposed. There are multitudes, no doubt, which will do so. There are multitudes who find the present opportunities for Sunday dissipation too limited, and fret and murmur against the restraints which the law imposes; but there are many who feel that this opening will bring no blessings to them, and will only multiply or increase the burdens under which they groan. They see that the enjoyments of a few will be purchased by the sufferings of many; wives and children will have to lament a home left without its natural guardian; parents will have to mourn over children drawn away from domestic control or religious observances; and the character of the day, as a day of rest, will be lost to all the inhabitants of that side of the metropolis.

Is this, then, a state of things which the legislature of England can countenance or permit? and will the sound sense of the British parliament be dazzled and blinded by the arts which have been employed to cloak the essential ungodliness of the proposal? We trust that there will be no hesitation or condescension in the tone of their answer. We trust that the representatives of the nation, conscious of the account they will have to give of the way in which they exercise their power, will seriously and calmly weigh the consequences of the measure brought before them, and, dismissing the illusions with which their imagination is assailed, will consider what the effects must be of legalizing a breach of one of God's commandments.

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